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Recent Legal Developments in Cryptocurrency and Virtual Asset Regulation in UAE, Jordan, and Morocco

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Posted by: [Ruth Levush](#)

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The following is a guest post by [George Sadek](#), a [senior foreign law specialist](#) at the [Law Library of Congress](#) covering laws of Arabic-speaking countries and [Islamic law](#). George has written numerous posts for *In Custodia Legis*, including the [New Multinational Report on the Acquisition of Citizenship through International Adoption](#), [FALQs: Qatar's New Counterterrorism Law](#), and [FALQ: Saudi Arabia Imposes Enhanced Penalties on Violators of Hajj Regulation](#).

I am writing this blog post to introduce the recent legal measures issued by Arab countries regulating [cryptocurrency](#) and [virtual assets](#). Three Arab countries have recently taken regulatory steps affecting cryptocurrencies and other virtual assets. These measures range from amendments to central banking laws and financial-free-zone regulations to the adoption of implementing regulations under newly enacted digital asset statutes and the publication of draft legislation. Collectively, these developments reflect a gradual shift toward more formal oversight of virtual asset activities in the region.



Cryptocurrencies. Photo by Flickr user Forextime.com, April 3, 2019. Used under CC BY 2.0 Deed, <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0/deed.en>

United Arab Emirates

In September 2025, the [United Arab Emirates](#) issued [Federal Decree-Law No. \(6\) of 2025](#) [\[PDF\]](#) Regarding the Central Bank, Regulation of Financial Institutions and Activities, and Insurance Business. The decree represents a significant step toward consolidating federal-level oversight of crypto-based payment services. Decree Law No. 6 of 2025 expands the list of regulated financial activities to include providing payment services using virtual assets, thereby bringing certain cryptocurrency-related activities more explicitly within the supervisory authority of the [Central Bank of the UAE](#) [\[PDF\]](#).

Furthermore, within the [Dubai International Financial Centre](#) ([\[PDF\]](#) DIFC), the [Dubai Financial Services Authority](#) [\[PDF\]](#) (DFSA) implemented amendments to its crypto token regime, effective January 12, 2026. Under the updated framework, regulated firms bear primary responsibility for assessing the suitability of crypto tokens, replacing the earlier approach that relied on a predefined list of recognized tokens. The amendments also emphasize strengthened governance, custody, disclosure, and compliance requirements for crypto-related activities conducted within the DIFC.

Additionally, in February 2026, the UAE Ministry of Finance announced the issuance of [Ministerial Decision No. \(336\) of 2025](#) [\[PDF\]](#), which designates [Dubai's Virtual Assets Regulatory Authority](#) [\[PDF\]](#) (VARA) as a competent authority for purposes related to the UAE corporate tax regime. While the decision does not establish substantive prudential rules for cryptocurrencies, it formally recognizes VARA's regulatory role within the broader legal framework governing virtual asset activities in Dubai.

Jordan

In January 2025, [Jordan](#) continued the implementation of its digital asset framework through subsidiary legislation, the [Virtual Assets Service Providers Licensing Regulation](#) [\[PDF\]](#) for the year 2025. This regulation sets out the regulatory framework for licensing virtual asset service providers in Jordan. The regulation defines key terms such as "virtual assets," "service

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providers,” “control,” and “related party,” and establishes that no entity may engage in virtual asset activities without a license issued by the [Jordanian Securities Commission](#). Applicants must meet specific structural criteria, including corporate form, minimum paid-up capital depending on the type of service, and detailed documentation on governance, technology, risk management, and anti-money-laundering policies to obtain preliminary approval and a full license. The regulation also specifies that applications must be submitted with supporting documents and that the Securities Commission will decide within defined timeframes.

Once licensed, service providers must adhere to ongoing compliance and operational standards to ensure transparency, client protection, and system security. The Jordanian Securities Commission is empowered to supervise, inspect, and enforce licensing conditions, with clear procedures for reporting, auditing, and handling breaches. The regulation outlines restrictions on risky business actions (such as misleading trading or unauthorized activities) and supervisory powers for the Securities Commission to suspend or cancel licenses if providers fail to comply. Fee structures for licensing and renewal, conditions for delegation to third parties, and provisions for [regulatory sandbox](#) participation are also included, reflecting Jordan’s approach to balancing innovation with investor protection in the evolving virtual assets sector. The regulation is scheduled to enter into force 30 days after its publication. The publication date was January 25, 2025.

Morocco

In November 2025, [Morocco](#) reportedly published [Draft Bill No. 42.25](#), which seeks to establish a comprehensive legal framework for digital assets, including cryptocurrencies and decentralized finance activities. Bill 42.25 moves beyond the [longstanding prohibition on cryptocurrency transactions under foreign-exchange rules](#). The draft legislation, prepared by the Ministry of Economy and Finance in cooperation with Bank Al-Maghrib and the Moroccan Capital Market Authority, aims to protect investors, uphold market integrity by combating fraud and money-laundering, foster innovation in financial technology, and safeguard financial stability by defining digital assets and setting out licensing and oversight provisions for activities such as issuance, trading, custody, and advisory services. Although this bill has not yet been enacted, its publication signals a policy shift toward the formal regulation of digital assets following years of restrictive treatment.

Additional resources

The Law Library published a report in 2018 on the [Regulation of Cryptocurrency Around the World](#). A [2021 update of the report](#) is available on the [Law Library of Congress](#) website.

For additional legal developments in the [UAE](#), [Jordan](#), and [Morocco](#), visit the Law Library resource, the [Global Legal Monitor](#), under the respective jurisdiction or under subject-specific [topics](#), such as [Cryptocurrency](#).

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